



Reading Your Dog's Body Language

Listening to the quiet signals, so your dog never has to shout

Dogs are talking to us all the time. They just don't use words. Every glance, ear position and shift of weight carries a message, and most of those messages are **polite, quiet requests** long before anything we'd call "aggressive" happens.

Veterinary surgeon and behaviourist **Kendal Shepherd** described this as a **Ladder of Aggression** (2004). A dog who is feeling uncomfortable starts on the bottom rungs with tiny, easily missed signals. If those signals are not noticed, and the pressure doesn't ease, the dog climbs higher, until growling, snapping or biting become the only options left.



Why it matters

Every rung is your dog saying "**I'm not comfortable.**" The lower down you notice it, the easier it is to help.

Some dogs move up slowly; others race to the top. A dog who has learned that quiet signals don't work may **skip rungs** altogether, which is why a bite can seem to come "out of nowhere".

Never punish a growl

A growl is an honest warning. Telling a dog off for growling doesn't remove the fear; it removes the **warning**. Next time, the dog may go straight to a snap.

Try this week

Spend a few minutes simply **watching** your dog: when the post arrives, when visitors come in, when you reach for the lead. Which bottom-rung signals do you spot? The more fluent you become in your dog's language, the sooner you can step in and help them feel safe.



Reading the Whole Dog

Eyes, ears, mouth, tail and body, all telling the same story

No single signal tells you everything. Look at the **whole dog**, from nose to tail, and at what is happening around them.

	Relaxed & comfortable	Worried or uncomfortable
Eyes	Soft, almond-shaped, blinking normally	Hard stare, or looking away. " Whale eye ": the whites of the eyes showing as the head turns away
Ears	Natural position for the breed, moving freely	Pinned back or flattened, or held stiffly forward and fixed
Mouth	Loose, slightly open, relaxed lips	Closed tight, lips drawn back, lip or nose licking, yawning out of context, panting when not hot
Tail	Natural height, loose wag that moves the hips	Tucked under, or held high and stiff, with a fast, tight wag
Body	Loose and wiggly, weight evenly spread, curving movement	Stiff or frozen, weight shifted back, crouched or making itself small, hackles raised
Movement	Sniffing, exploring, choosing to come close	Turning away, leaving, shaking off as if wet, sudden scratching or sniffing to avoid something

Context is everything

A **wagging tail** doesn't always mean a happy dog; it means an aroused one. A **yawn** after a long walk is probably tiredness; a yawn as a stranger leans over them probably isn't.

Ask yourself: *what just happened, and what is my dog trying to tell me about it?*

⚠ Freeze and stare: be extra vigilant

A dog who suddenly goes **still** and fixes a **hard stare** is very near the top of the ladder. A snap or bite may only be seconds away.

Don't reach for them, lean over them or stare back. Calmly **create distance**: turn side-on, soften your gaze and move away, or ask others to.

What you can do when you see the signals

- **Pause.** Stop what you, or the other person or dog, are doing.
- **Create distance.** Calmly move your dog away, or ask others to give space. Curve away rather than turning head-on.
- **Let your dog choose.** Allow them to approach, or not, in their own time. Consent matters to dogs too.
- **Thank the warning.** Never punish a growl or any other signal; respond to the feeling behind it.
- **Keep notes.** Jot down what triggered the signals and where. Patterns help us plan your dog's support.

When we listen to the whispers, our dogs don't need to shout.